Count Vincenzo Von Goth had been undead for 842 years, had sucked the blood of 3,247 humans (plus one very unfortunate mannequin), and memorized all 24 seasons of America's Next Top Model. He was immortal, stylish, and hopelessly bored.

Immortality, as it turned out, was far less thrilling than advertised. He owned a Transylvanian castle he never cleaned, a cape collection that could be classified as obsessive, and he even tried therapy once, but the mirrorless office really threw him off.

And so, naturally, in a fit of existential ennui and Wi-Fi withdrawal, he bought a sketchy "Time Crystal" from an even sketchier warlock named Dave. Dave looked like a failed magician who had gotten stuck in the middle of a Dungeons & Dragons cosplay.

"Only turn the crystal clockwise," Dave had warned. "And once the time is up, you'll be back to—" but he impulsively ignored the rest of that part.

Count Vinny (he insisted on being called that in casual settings) was more of a vibe guy than a read-the-labels guy. And he was desperate. He needed a shake-up. A new era. A fresh set of jugulars.

He turned it counterclockwise. Because of course he did.

There was a bright green flash, a sound like a werewolf sneezing into a tuba, and the familiar sensation of being yanked backward through a cosmic plumbing system.

Then silence.

Vinny landed face-first in a fern.

He sat up slowly, blinking against the sunlight. Everything was green. Not the dull green of 21st-century parks, but a thick, wet, unapologetically lush green. Trees as tall as buildings loomed overhead, and the air smelled like wet moss.

"Dios mio," Vinny muttered, dusting himself off in full velvet regalia. "Did I time-travel to Jurassic Park's deleted scenes?"

His thoughts were interrupted by a deafening screech and the arrival of what could only be described as a prehistoric chicken on steroids. A Therizinosaurus (though Vinny wouldn't know that) charged at him with its terrifying claws extended.

Vinny did what any ancient vampire with centuries of dark power would do.

He screamed and ran. Very fast. Like blur-on-the-horizon fast.

Unfortunately, vampire speed in a dense jungle was like using a Lamborghini in a hedge maze. He zoomed face-first into a tree. Twice.

The next few days were a survivalist comedy of errors. He attempted to bite a Triceratops, who promptly launched him ten feet into the air with its head. He crept up on a sauropod, only to discover that its skin was roughly the texture of concrete. A raptor chased him up a tree when he tried to hypnotize it, and at one point, a pterosaur mistook him for a mate and wouldn't stop following him.

Feeding, it turned out, was a problem. He tried going vegan, but berries gave him diarrhea. Tree bark wasn't technically vegan, but he gave it a shot anyway, and immediately regretted it when his mouth filled with ants. For the first time in eight centuries, Count Vinny felt truly vulnerable.

Weak, muddy, and emotionally defeated, he collapsed one afternoon near a giant nest full of eggs the size of beanbag chairs.

And then she arrived.

The ground thundered beneath her steps. Her head loomed above him, eyes scanning the scene. She was massive, majestic, terrifying.

A Tyrannosaurus rex.

Vinny braced for death. He tried to muster a witty last word. Something like, Tell Dracula I never paid that bar tab. But instead, she… nuzzled him?

With a proud, rumbling growl, she inspected the eggs. Two were cracking open. Slimy, shrieking hatchlings wriggled free.

Then she looked at him again.

Vinny, pale and covered in slime, flailed one arm weakly.

The T. Rex blinked slowly.

Then she leaned down and licked him clean.

From that moment on, he was part of the family.

Vinny, somehow, became the third baby.

At first, it was chaos. He was too slow, too bony, and screamed whenever he saw bugs. His "siblings", who he later named Jibbles and Murderbaby, were aggressive and adorable in equal measure. Murderbaby tried to eat him twice. Jibbles once sat on him for an hour. But their mother, whom Vinny affectionately dubbed Big Mama, treated him like her own.

She taught her babies to hunt by demonstrating how to stalk prey. Vinny was less “stealthy predator” and more “panicked man in a cape falling out of a tree.” He tried to charm a herd of duck-billed dinosaurs and got headbutted into a river.

But slowly, things began to change.

He started helping. He couldn’t kill, but he could distract. His vampire speed, useless when he was crashing into trees, suddenly became an asset. He would zip around in erratic zigzags, screeching and flapping his arms, confusing herds just long enough for Murderbaby to pounce. And once the prey was down, feeding got a lot easier. Nothing like a freshly torn-apart, ready-to-eat dinner to lift a vampire’s spirits.

He once ran so fast through a pack of confused stegosaurs that they panicked and trampled each other in a daisy-chain of tail spikes and regret. Vinny limped away proudly with a bruised rib and a sense of purpose.

His screams, once useless, became tactical. His speed, once ridiculous, became vital.

He grew close to them. He shared leaves with Murderbaby when his stomach hurt. He watched Jibbles pounce for the first time and actually cried, then pretended he had dirt in his eye. Big Mama roared lullabies at night, and Vinny found himself snuggling between the warm, snoring babies, feeling safer than he had in centuries.

In that nest of monsters, he found peace.

And then the crystal activated.

It buzzed softly from his tattered boot one night under a full moon. He pulled it out, now glowing bright blue and humming with time energy, as if saying time was up.

Big Mama looked at him. She seemed to understand. She bent her massive head and nudged him gently.

Vinny pressed his face against her scales. “You were the best mother I ever had. Even though you did try to regurgitate a goat into my mouth that one time.”

He turned the crystal clockwise.

Another flash.

And suddenly… fluorescent lights, Air conditioning. Someone screamed, “Sir, put on pants!”

He was sprawled on the floor of a 24/7 grocery store in Brooklyn, naked and confused.

His skin was warm. His fangs were gone. He caught sight of himself in the freezer door, and his reflection stared back. He was human again, alive!

He laughed. Then cried. Then screamed again when he saw the price of almond milk.

Within the month, he found a job as a tour guide at the Natural History Museum. The kids loved him. He told wild stories about dinosaurs and time travel. No one believed him, of course, except one little girl who tugged on his pants one day and asked, “Do dinosaurs have families like us?”

He smiled.

“Some of them do,” he said. “And if you’re really lucky, they might adopt you.”